

Fitzpatrick Skin Type Classification

Complete classification guide with treatment implications for laser, IPL, peels, and injectables

FITZPATRICK CLASSIFICATION SYSTEM

Type	Description	Sun History	Melanin	Population
Type I	Very fair. Ivory/pale white. Freckles common	Always burns severely. Never tans	Lowest	Northern European — Irish, Scottish, Scandinavian
Type II	Fair. White to light beige	Usually burns. Rarely tans minimally	Low	European — English, German, French
Type III	Medium. Beige/light brown	Sometimes burns mildly. Tans gradually (light brown)	Medium	Southern European, some Asian, some Latino
Type IV	Olive/moderate brown	Rarely burns. Tans easily to moderate brown	Medium-high	Mediterranean, Hispanic, Asian, Middle Eastern
Type V	Brown/dark brown	Very rarely burns. Tans easily (dark brown)	High	South Asian, African American (lighter), Latino
Type VI	Very dark brown to black	Never burns. Tans deeply	Highest	African, very dark South Asian, Aboriginal

LASER & IPL SAFETY BY FITZPATRICK

Treatment	Type I-II	Type III	Type IV	Type V-VI
IPL Photo-rejuvenation	Excellent — first choice	Good with care	Moderate risk — test patch required	Contraindicated — high burn and PIH risk
Nd:YAG 1064nm (hair)	Not ideal (poor melanin target)	Acceptable	Good — safer long wavelength	Preferred — safest wavelength for dark skin
755nm Alexandrite (hair)	Excellent	Good	Use caution — test patch	Contraindicated — too much epidermal melanin absorption
CO2 Fractional	Excellent	Good — conservative settings	Conservative settings, test patch	Avoid or very conservative — significant PIH risk
Non-ablative fractional (1550nm)	Excellent	Good	Acceptable with conservative approach	Use with caution — lower energy, more passes
KTP 532nm (vascular)	Excellent — green wavelength targets vessels	Good	Use caution	Avoid — epidermal melanin competes, burn risk

PEEL SELECTION BY FITZPATRICK

Fitzpatrick	Safe Peel Choices	Depth Limit	Pre-Treatment Required
I-II	All AHAs, BHAs, TCA up to 35%, Jessner's	Medium depth safe	Standard SPF protocol
III	Glycolic up to 50%, lactic, mandelic, salicylic, low TCA	Superficial to light medium	SPF + hydroquinone for TCA
IV	Mandelic preferred. Low glycolic/lactic. Salicylic 10-20%. TCA ≤15% only	Superficial only	Mandatory: hydroquinone 4-6 wks + SPF
V-VI	Mandelic acid only for superficial. No TCA. No Jessner's	Superficial only — very conservative	Mandatory: kojic + hydroquinone + SPF 4-6 wks pre-peel

MICRONEEDLING DEPTH BY FITZPATRICK

Fitzpatrick	Safe Needle Depth	Energy Level (RF)	PIH Risk	Special Considerations
I-II	0.5–2.5mm as indicated	Full energy range	Low	Aggressive treatment well tolerated. Minimal PIH concern
III	0.5–2.0mm	Moderate to full energy	Low-Moderate	Standard protocols. Some PIH risk — SPF critical post-treatment
IV	0.5–1.5mm	Conservative to moderate	Moderate	Reduce energy. Conservative depth. SPF 50+ immediately post-treatment
V-VI	0.5–1.0mm only	Conservative — reduce 20–30% from standard	High	Most conservative approach. Longer healing intervals. Vigilant sun avoidance post-treatment

FILLER & BOTOX CONSIDERATIONS BY SKIN TYPE

All Fitzpatrick types	Injectables themselves have no Fitzpatrick-specific contraindication — technique, not skin color, determines safety
Bruising visibility	Bruising more visible in lighter skin (I-II). Darker skin (V-VI) may show bruising differently — purple to black tones
Keloid risk	Patients with Fitzpatrick V-VI have higher keloid/hypertrophic scar risk. Relevant for any puncture — use smallest gauge appropriate
PIH from injection	Any injection that causes significant trauma or inflammation can trigger PIH in darker skin types — use fine gauge, minimize trauma
Tyndall effect	Blue-gray discoloration from superficial HA is MORE visible in Fitzpatrick I-III due to lighter overlying skin — inject at correct depth

ASSESSMENT TIPS — HOW TO DETERMINE FITZPATRICK TYPE

- ★ Ask: "What happens to your skin when you go in the sun without protection for 30 minutes?" — the answer is the most reliable classifier
- ★ Do NOT classify by skin color alone — a medium-toned patient who never burns is Type IV or V behaviorally, even if they appear lighter
- ★ Mixed heritage patients often have different Fitzpatrick responses than expected from appearance — always ask
- ★ Document the Fitzpatrick type in every patient chart — it affects laser settings, peel selection, and treatment planning permanently